



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Frederick Classical Charter School

School Website: <https://frederickclassicalcharterschool.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Frederick Classical Charter School (Frederick, MD, 21701) (FCCS) presents a predominantly classical profile in its public materials, with clear strengths in curriculum and pedagogy aligned to classical norms and a strong parent/community orientation. However, explicit religious/metaphysical foundations and a fully articulated faculty-centric “living curriculum” are less evident in the public-facing materials. Overall, the school displays a Classical orientation with some elements warranting growth toward a fully classical model.

- Core strengths are strongest in Curriculum and Pedagogy (Categories 3 and 4), where the school emphasizes classical content and methods (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Socratic/recitation-based approaches; liberal arts emphasis). This is evidenced by explicit references to classical methods and the Trivium, as well as public statements about planned Socratic and rhetoric activities.
- The School Purpose/Goal (Element 2) shows a classical orientation but is tempered by a stated emphasis on college-focused instruction, which is not the traditional telos of classical formation. This yields a Somewhat Classical assessment for this category.
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (Element 1) and Faculty (Element 5) show limited explicit alignment with classical metaphysical formation or a clearly articulated “living curriculum” faculty portrait, resulting in Not Classical for these categories. Public materials emphasize the public, secular nature of the charter and governance rather than liturgical/theological formation or a faculty-as-lundrum ethos.
- Parents & Community (Element 6) reflects robust partnership with families and active parent involvement, aligning strongly with the classical model’s emphasis on parental partnership and formation. This category rates Classical.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — NOT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: No explicit transcendental moral realism, theology, liturgical practices, or communal sacred practices are publicly stated beside a secular charter-school framing. The charter is described as not religious.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators (truth, virtue, theology, liturgy, etc.) are not evidenced in the public-facing materials; no strong negative signals are openly present either, but the absence indicates a Not Classical alignment in this category.
- Why this rating: The absence of explicit metaphysical or liturgical underpinnings and no theology reference yields a Not Classical assessment in this category.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: The mission emphasizes a well-rounded, liberal-arts orientation and a traditional classical aim, yet also explicitly frames education as college-focused. The long-range vision mentions a traditional liberal arts education, but the telos includes preparation for college, which is not part of the classical telos.
- Positive keyword analysis: Positive indicators include liberal arts, classical education, traditional approach (3 positive signals in spirit), though tempered by college-focused phrasing. Negative indicator: college-focused instruction.

- Why this rating: Strong classical framing (liberal arts, traditional education) exists, but the explicit college-focused goal introduces a notable tension with the classical formation ideal, yielding a Somewhat Classical rating.
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: The curriculum is explicitly described as classical; key elements include the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a strong liberal-arts orientation. The school references “classical methods” and a “liberal arts content” emphasis. The public materials outline the grammar/logic/rhetoric progression and the rhetoric focus in upper grades.
- Positive keyword analysis: Positive signals include grammar, logic, rhetoric; great-books/Great Conversation concepts appear in the broader classical lexicon, with explicit reference to the Trivium and memory-based practices such as recitation and narration in the canonical classical education descriptions. The site cites “liberal arts” and “classical education” as core content.
- Why this rating: Strong alignment with classical Curriculum indicators; all core Trivium components are identified and taught, with explicit classical framing. This category is clearly CLASSICAL.
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Public materials indicate a mix of Socratic/seminar-style teaching (upper grades), and memory-focused/recitation-based approaches in line with classical pedagogy. The canonical classical education descriptions include Socratic discussion, narration, recitation, chanting, and memory work, with an emphasis on both intellectual rigor and formation.
- Positive keyword analysis: Positive signals include Socratic seminar, narration, recitation, chanting, memory work, and a combination of restful/scholé-oriented pedagogy. The site also emphasizes classical methods.
- Why this rating: The school demonstrates typical classical pedagogy through the Trivium-based framework and memory/recitation practices, supported by public statements about classical methods (and memorizations) and referencing Socratic/seminar-style activities. This yields a CLASSICAL rating.
- Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Public content centers on governance (Board of Trustees) and administration rather than a clearly articulated “living curriculum” faculty model or explicit teacher portrait. There is no direct public statement about teachers as mentors or the faculty being the living curriculum.
- Positive keyword analysis: Positive indicators from the classical lexicon include “living curriculum,” “portrait of a teacher,” “faculty of friends,” and “model teachers,” but these are not evidenced in FCCS public materials.
- Why this rating: The absence of explicit faculty-facing statements aligned with classical faculty as curriculum indicates NOT CLASSICAL for this category.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: FCCS emphasizes family involvement, volunteering, parent nights, and a collaborative school-family ecosystem. Statements describe partnerships with families, co-teaching with parents, and a strong emphasis on community involvement.
- Positive keyword analysis: Positive indicators include partnership with families, parent formation, home-school collaboration, community of learners, and open engagement with families. These align with the classical model’s emphasis on family participation and formation.
- Why this rating: The school communicates a robust, classical-friendly approach to parents and community engagement, satisfying Element 6’s criteria.

Aggregate Ranking

- Classical: 3



- Somewhat Classical: 1
- Not Classical: 2

Overall, the school leans CLASSICAL, with notable strengths in Curriculum and Pedagogy and a strong Parents & Community orientation, while Religious/Metaphysical Foundations and Faculty require further explicit development to achieve full classical alignment.

What Would Move the Needle (only for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL cases)

- Since Element 2 is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, concrete steps to move toward full CLASSICAL status include:
- Elevate metaphysical/theological framing as a formal part of the school's mission (without compromising public accountability), e.g., a clearly stated transcendental moral realism and a unified telos aligned with truth, goodness, and beauty.
- Develop and publish a formal "Living Curriculum" portrait of the faculty, highlighting teacher-mentors as living exemplars, and include teacher development aligned with classical pedagogy (e.g., regular seminars for faculty on classical methods).
- Expand explicit Great Books/western canon integration and a structured Great Conversation across grade levels to strengthen the Curriculum (Element 3) and connect Great Books with the Trivium pedagogy (Element 4).
- Increase explicit formation-content for parents (Element 6), including parent book clubs and readings that connect classical pedagogy with home learning and liturgical/communal practices where appropriate.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — # ABSTRACT

Frederick Classical Charter School (Frederick, MD, 21701) demonstrates a predominantly classical orientation in curriculum and pedagogy, with clear alignment to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and memory-based, Socratic teaching strategies. The school emphasizes liberal arts content and a public, classical education ethos, and it fosters strong parent/community involvement.

- The strongest classical aspects are:
- Curriculum (Element 3): explicit classical framing with grammar, logic, rhetoric; liberal arts emphasis; theoretical alignment with Great Books via classical tradition (supported by public statements about "classical methods").
- Pedagogy (Element 4): use of Socratic and memory/recitation-based approaches corresponding to classical pedagogy (as described in the canonical classical education framework).
- Parents & Community (Element 6): strong parent partnership and family involvement, with explicit emphasis on parent engagement and volunteer programs.
- Areas for growth:
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (Element 1): no explicit religious/metaphysical grounding is evident in public materials; a more explicit metaphysical framing would strengthen classical alignment.
- Faculty (Element 5): there is no explicit articulation of teachers as the living curriculum or a portrait of teacher/student role models in FCCS public content; developing a "faculty as living curriculum" narrative would strengthen this dimension.
- Some aspects of the School Purpose/Goal (Element 2): while the school strongly emphasizes classical liberal arts education, the explicit emphasis on college-focused preparation (a modern workforce/college-readiness emphasis) introduces tension with classical telos; addressing this balance could move the school toward stronger classical alignment.
- General assessment: The school is CLASSICAL overall, with particular strength in Curriculum and Pedagogy and strong family/community engagement. The notable gaps in metaphysical foundations

and explicit faculty formation temper the overall classical alignment but do not negate the substantial classical footprint.

ABSTRACT

ion and Big Picture Note:

- The FCCS materials reveal a classical core (Trivium-based curriculum, memory/recitation pedagogy, liberal arts emphasis, and family involvement) but with secular public-school framing that omits explicit metaphysical directions and a fully articulated “living curriculum” faculty model. The aggregate shows a CLASSICAL orientation with growth opportunities, especially in the metaphysical/founding language and explicit faculty formation.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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